



Coursework Brief and Front Sheet PGT

This front sheet for assessments is designed to contain the brief, the submission instructions, and the actual student submission for any WMG assessment. As a result, the sheet is completed by several people over time and is therefore split up into sections explaining who completes what information and when. Yellow highlighted text indicates examples or further explanation of what is requested, and the highlight and instructions should be removed as you populate 'your' section. This sheet is only to be used for components of assessment worth more than 3 CATS (e.g. for a 15 credit module, weighted more than 20%; or for a 10 credit module, weighted more than 30%).

To be completed (highlighted parts only) by the Programme Administration after approval and prior to issuing of the assessment; to be consulted by the Student(s) so that you know how and when to submit:

Date set	9 February 2026
Submission date (excluding extensions)	09/03/2026 by 12 pm UK time
Submission guidance	Tabula link
Marks return date (excluding extensions)	08/04/2026

To be completed by the Module Leader/Tutor prior to approval and issuing of the assessment; to be briefed to the Student(s) so that they understand the Coursework Brief, its context within the module, and any specific criteria and advice from the tutor:

Module Title & Code	Innovative Simulation Design and Development WM9G2-15
Component Type	Design assignment
Module Leader	Devon Allcoat
Module Tutor	See Above
Assessment Title	Design
Weighting (%)	70%

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Game Title: Dreamweaver: Cross-Cultural Nightmare Puzzle

1.Design Brief

1 Game concept

Dreamweaver is a narrative-driven exploration puzzle-solving game with a touch of horror. Players take on the role of a dream interpreter, using a dreamcatcher to enter the dreams of others, searching for the causes of nightmares, and helping the dream's owner overcome their fears through puzzle-solving and exploration.

The game's core feature is its cross-cultural dream chapter structure. Each chapter is based on folklore from different countries or regions, such as Chinese ghost marriages, Japanese shrine legends, European forest spirits, and the Mexican Day of the Dead. Players explore the environment within the dream, collect clues, and gradually piece together a complete story hidden behind the dreams.

Hidden Main Story: Although each chapter is an independent story, as the game progresses, players will discover that all dreams are connected to a single, overarching nightmare. This nightmare leaves traces in the dreams of different cultures, and in the final chapter, players discover that this nightmare actually originates from their own subconscious—the dream interpreter is not a completely independent entity, but rather someone also within the dream. Ultimately, players must enter their own dream and confront their deepest fears.

Unlike traditional horror games, this game doesn't simply create scares; instead, it aims to help players understand the myths, taboos, and customs of different cultures. It employs a more gentle, cozy-horror narrative style, and this contrast makes the game more suspenseful. The game emphasizes story exploration and cultural atmosphere.

2 Game type

Narrative Puzzle Exploration, visually contrasting design, fragmented narrative, cross-cultural horror narrative, and dreams as the game space.

3 gaming platform

PC (Digital platforms such as Steam)

Reasons for choosing the PC platform include:

More convenient development and testing

More suitable for narrative and exploration games, offering better visual presentation and a higher level of player immersion.

4 Core gameplay

The core gameplay loop is as follows:

Enter the dream



Explore the dream environment



Collect clues and memory fragments



Understand the cause of the nightmare



Solve puzzles and purify the dream

Players need to observe unusual phenomena in dreams to determine the type of nightmare, such as recurring events, abnormal mirroring, or changes in spatial structure. Then, they need to identify the archetype of fear, such as namelessness (identity erased), loss of virginity (body controlled), or loss of home (family broken). Players must use clues to determine which type of fear the nightmare belongs to. Once determined, players need to use the corresponding cultural intervention method. For example, in a Chinese ghost marriage dream, disrupting the red thread ceremony/changing the order of memorial tablets; in a Japanese shrine dream, using a mirror to find the correct path; in a European forest dream, triggering the altar according to the legend. When the intervention is correct, the dream structure will change. When the story fragments are collected, the story is pieced together, the nightmare is broken, and the dream is healed.

Gameplay: 2.5D perspective, traditional HOPA gameplay. Players move through a complex scene map, using WASD to move, searching for specific items, and using the F key for interaction. Interaction prompts will only appear when specific clue items are found. Key items are added to the inventory system. Players then advance the plot through various mechanisms, logic puzzles, or mini-games, moving between different scenes to collect items and solve problems.

5 Game Features

Key features of this game include:

Cross-cultural story structure: Each chapter is based on folk tales from different cultures, giving the game the potential for continuous expansion.

Environmental narrative: The story unfolds gradually through environmental details, fragmented memories, and visual symbols, rather than extensive textual explanations.

Warm and terrifying style: The game's visuals employ an art style reminiscent of picture books or paper-cutting, similar to the colorful paper-cutting visuals of *Moomintroll: Winter's Warmth*, creating a fairytale-like sense of mystery without being oppressive.

Reduce scare intensity mode: The horror is conveyed more through atmosphere and textual differences than through sudden, overwhelming attacks. This aligns with recent discussions on whether "cozy and horror" can coexist: comfort does not equate to the absence of horror, but rather emphasizes controllability and adjustability. (Lindsey Barnick, 2025)



Figure 1: Visual style of the Moomin game



Figure 2: Visual style of the Moomin game picture book, featuring a lonely and empty atmosphere.

6 Target Audience

The primary target players for this game include: players who enjoy narrative-driven games, players who enjoy exploration and puzzle-solving, and players who are interested in different cultures and folk tales. These players typically prioritize the story experience and atmosphere over high-difficulty gameplay challenges.

2. Game Instructions

1 Player Objective

The player's goal is to enter a dream world, explore the environment, solve puzzles to uncover the cause of the nightmare, and ultimately purify the dream.

Upon completing each chapter, players will uncover a full story and help the dream's inhabitant overcome their fear. 惧

2 Basic Operations

Players explore through simple movement and interaction.

Common actions include: moving the character, observing the environment, collecting clues, and interacting with objects. Most puzzles require players to combine or deduce different clues.

3 Game Flow

Each chapter typically consists of the following stages:

Dream Entry

Players enter the dream scene and begin exploring the environment.

Clues Gathering

Players need to find key items or information in the environment, such as symbols, diaries, or memory fragments.

Puzzle Solving

By analyzing clues, players can solve puzzles, such as unlocking hidden areas or restoring order to the dream.

Nightmare Purification

Once players understand the cause of the nightmare and complete the final puzzle, the dream gradually returns to normal.

4 Prompt System

To prevent players from getting stuck on a puzzle for too long, the game provides a hint system.

If a player lingers on the same puzzle for too long, the system will provide progressive hints, such as: hinting at an important object in the environment; or hinting at the relationship between clues. This maintains the challenge while preventing the game experience from being interrupted.

5 Illustrated Guide System

The cultural information players collect in the game is recorded in the encyclopedia, including: Nightmare type, folklore background, and discovered clues. The encyclopedia not only records game progress but also helps players understand the stories of different cultures.

6 Cultural Studies Cards

Since this game involves knowledge of folk culture from different countries, high credibility of localization is crucial. To enhance the credibility of cultural expression, the game provides optional "cultural annotation cards" for some cultural elements, introducing their origins, background context, and related taboos. Players can toggle these cards on and off without interrupting the game's flow. The aim is to improve credibility and rigor.

3. Accompanying Essay

introduction

This article analyzes the design concept of a narrative puzzle game. The core gameplay revolves around the player taking on the role of a "dream interpreter," entering the dreams of people from different cultural backgrounds to uncover the causes of nightmares and help the dream's inhabitants overcome their fears through puzzle-solving and exploration.

The game's content draws from folk tales around the world, such as Chinese ghost marriages, Japanese shrine legends, and European forest tales. Each chapter represents a cultural background, presented through dreams. Players collect clues and memory fragments during their exploration, gradually piecing together the complete story.

Unlike traditional horror games, this game emphasizes narrative experience and cultural expression rather than relying on intense scares. The overall visual style employs an art form reminiscent of picture books or paper-cutting to create a mysterious yet gentle atmosphere.

This article will analyze the game concept from four aspects: game development process, technical tools, target players, and design implementation.

L01: Development process from concept to product

Game development typically involves multiple phases, including concept design, prototyping, content expansion, and final release.

In the concept phase, the game's theme, core gameplay, and overall visual style need to be determined. The core concept of this game is understanding the source of fear through dream exploration; therefore, the game needs to emphasize environmental narrative and puzzle design.

In the prototyping phase, a basic dream scenario needs to be created, and a basic exploration and interaction system implemented. The goal of this phase is to verify the feasibility of the core gameplay, such as whether players can obtain clues by observing the environment, and whether the puzzles are reasonably challenging.

Subsequently, a complete chapter can be created as a "vertical slice." This chapter needs to include a complete exploration flow, puzzle design, and narrative structure. This method allows for testing the game's overall experience and adjustments based on player feedback.

If the vertical slice performs well, the game can move into the content expansion phase. Because the game uses a chapter structure, each cultural story is relatively independent, so new chapters can be added gradually without affecting the overall structure.

Near completion, player testing is also necessary to evaluate puzzle difficulty, narrative comprehension, and overall game pacing. After adjustments based on the test results, the game can be released on the Steam platform, and new cultural chapters can be added later.

Title	Release Year	Developer	Similarities	Differences	Inspiration for My Concept
Neverending Nightmares	2014	InfiniTap Games	Uses "layered nightmare" themes with strong psychological horror and atmosphere	Focuses on one person's mental distress; cultural dimension is weaker; black-and-white oppressive art style	Dream settings can use "symptom → spatial transformation" as gameplay feedback, but the boundary of mental-health themes should be clearly defined
Yomawari: Night Alone	2016 (PC)	Nippon Ichi Software, Inc.	Exploration driven by folklore / yokai atmosphere; low mechanical barrier	Strong single Japanese cultural style; focuses more on survival horror and evasion	Demonstrates that "cute visuals + horror atmosphere" contrast works well and can be adapted into a softer form of horror
Detention	2017	Red Candle Games	Combines East Asian cultural symbols with horror narrative; point-and-click exploration and puzzles	Cultural background tightly tied to Taiwan's specific historical context; theme is more serious	Shows the need to build a "cultural evidence chain + mature narrative hints" , avoiding using cultural symbols only as decoration
Oxenfree	2016	Night School Studio	Atmosphere-driven storytelling; supernatural and psychological themes; suitable pacing for interactive narrative	Dialogue choice is the core mechanic; folklore elements are not the main focus	Dialogue systems should serve the exploration of fear archetypes , rather than being simple branching choices; provide contextual narrative triggers
Rusty Lake: Roots	2016	Rusty Lake	Puzzle solving with surreal and psychological hints; strong symbolic system and "archive-like" experience	Single fictional world setting (not cross-cultural); more allegorical narrative	Provides a chapter-based template : each chapter has its own mechanic hook while contributing to a larger mystery
Paper Cut Mansion	2022	Space Lizard Studio	Papercraft / handmade visual style combined with horror atmosphere; puzzle-driven progression; emphasis on "evidence board / clue organization"	Roguelite replay structure with stronger combat elements; theme is not cross-cultural folklore	Papercraft visuals can coexist with horror; evidence board / archive-style UI can inspire interactive dream-journal mechanics

Figure 3: Comparison with six similar works

L02: Tool and technology selection

The MDA (Mechanics–Dynamics–Aesthetics) model helps transform abstract game concepts into concrete system designs.

Mechanics: Clue gathering, fear archetype identification, cultural intervention puzzles, and encyclopedia unlocking.

Dynamics: Players gradually reduce uncertainty through a cycle of "unknown—inference—verification";

Aesthetics: Shifting from "fear" to "understanding and healing," creating controllable tension through visual contrast.

Technically, this game uses the Unity game engine. Unity is widely used in indie game development, offering excellent cross-platform support and a wealth of development tools, making it ideal for narrative and puzzle games. Its advantages also include rapid prototyping, a rich resource ecosystem, and comprehensive editor tools. These features allow for more efficient implementation of game functionality.

For resource management, Unity's Addressables system can be used for on-demand loading. When a player enters a new dream chapter, only the corresponding resources are loaded, reducing memory usage and improving loading efficiency.

For data management, ScriptableObjects can be used to store game configurations, such as puzzle information, nightmare types, and chapter data. This data-driven approach reduces code modifications and improves development efficiency.

In terms of narrative management, interactive narrative tools such as Ink are used to manage dialogue and plot structure, making it easier to construct fragmented narratives.

L03: Target players and design requirements

The core motivation of this game is not a high-pressure survival challenge, but rather immersive atmosphere, reasoning, and cultural understanding. Therefore, the target players can be divided into two categories:

Core players: Players who enjoy narrative-driven puzzles and atmospheric horror but don't crave intense scares;

Extended players: Players interested in cross-cultural mythology/folklore and willing to read encyclopedias and collect fragmented narratives (closer to a "playable knowledge base" experience).

Publicly available tags and descriptions of similar works can serve as evidence of "audience expectations": for example, some works are labeled Story Rich, Atmospheric, Psychological Horror, Puzzle, etc., indicating that players have relatively clear expectations for "emotional and narrative tension" and "puzzle progression."

The definition of "cozy horror" emphasizes familiarity, distance, and a "fun/non-overwhelming" horror experience, which aligns with this project's theme of "not simply creating scares, but understanding fear." Therefore, player needs extend beyond just "fun puzzles" to include psychological safety boundaries: content hints, controllable pacing, mild penalties for failure, and respectful presentation of cultural symbols.

The primary target audience for this game is players who enjoy narrative-driven and puzzle-solving games. These players typically prioritize story experience, world-building, and atmosphere over high-intensity gameplay challenges.

Through these design choices, the game maintains narrative depth without overly complex mechanics that raise the barrier to entry for players.

L04: Design Process and Implementation

Game design can be divided into three main phases.

The first phase is concept design. This phase involves determining the game's theme, core gameplay, and visual style. The core concept of this game is "eliminating nightmares through understanding fear," therefore, the visual design adopts a picture book style to reduce the oppressive feeling of traditional horror games.

The concept: To ensure each chapter is independently playable while maintaining a cohesive overall theme, the game incorporates a nightmare encyclopedia (fear encyclopedia), establishing several unified fear archetypes, such as loss of name, loss of virginity, loss of home, loss of family, loss of control, and amnesia. Different cultures use different cultural legends to express a particular fear archetype. Ultimately, players will eliminate these fears, healing their dreams and helping humanity confront fear. This provides a clear sense of closure at the end of each chapter. The core theme is: fear originates from culture and also from within.

The second phase is prototype development. This requires creating a basic dream scenario and implementing an exploration, interaction, and simple puzzle system to validate the core gameplay.

The third phase is vertical segment development. This requires completing a full cultural chapter, including environment design, puzzles, narrative, and the encyclopedia system. This chapter should fully showcase the core gameplay experience.

These design choices directly address the needs of the target players, thus ensuring a consistent design logic across game mechanics, narrative style, and visual style, guaranteeing that the player experience aligns with the design goals. For example, simple controls lower the barrier to entry, environmental storytelling enhances the narrative experience, and the hint system prevents players from getting stuck for extended periods.

If the vertical slice test is successful, the game can continue to expand with new cultural chapters and gradually refine the overall plot structure.

Conclusion

This article analyzes the design concept of a cross-cultural folklore puzzle game. The game combines folk tales from different cultures with puzzle gameplay through dream-like narratives, providing players with a unique exploration experience.

The chapter-based structure allows for continuous expansion of the game, while an encyclopedia system helps players understand different cultural backgrounds. Creating vertical slices and conducting player testing effectively validates the core gameplay and reduces development risks.

If this design is successfully implemented, the game will not only provide a culturally distinctive narrative experience but also possess significant long-term expansion potential.

Reference:

Lindsey Barnick, (2025)

Finding Comfort in the Spooky: Cozy Horror Video Games

Available

at:<https://www.museumofplay.org/blog/finding-comfort-in-the-spooky-cozy-horror-video-games/>

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